



road or lane which makes people using a wheelchair feel independent. There's even a system at traffic signals that helps us cross the road. Such things should be introduced in India too.

The government builds lifts and ramps in many buildings for accessibility, but these facilities are not maintained properly. Even the elderly and pregnant women need such requirements, not just us.

You couldn't recreate your Tokyo performance at the 2024 Paris Paralympics. What do you think went wrong?

I'm happy with my performance. I was playing China's Ying Zhou in the quarterfinals and gave my best. I don't have any regrets from that tournament. They [Chinese players] never let their strategy leak. Tactics, facilities — they have everything. It's their game; they're almost trained like robots.

Recently, you attended the opening ceremony of the UTT. Did you speak to the organisers about the possibility of a UTT for para table tennis players?

I spoke to Vita Dani ma'am about possibly starting a UTT for para table tennis players. It'll give them a platform to show the level of their game. It can also be a confidence booster.

After seeing your rise in the sport, are there others from your village who want to take up table tennis and follow your path?

There are many athletes coming up in Gujarat, but the stadiums either don't have a table or are too far away. I have tables at my home and try to call players over for training.

After I retire, I wish to give India an athlete who goes on to play at the Paralympics. I want to establish an academy to guide athletes from their

Unforgettable moment: At the Tokyo 2021 Paralympics, Bhavina Patel made history as the first Indian table tennis player to win a Paralympic medal. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

early stages right up to the Paralympics.

And I'll do this free of cost because I don't want them to face the financial hurdles I had to overcome.

What more do you think can be done to help and improve para sports in India?

The government has provided a lot of support through schemes like TOPS, but I feel some of the funding that goes to already established athletes — who have their own sponsors — could go to beginners and grassroots athletes. That would help talent come up from the remotest areas, across all disciplines.